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Senior Drupal Front-End Developer — Drupal / Acquia Case Studies

Below are three recent projects delivered as Lead Frontend Developer, covering Drupal 11 builds across the tourism, environmental and higher-education sectors, including an Acquia-hosted platform. Each includes the project context, my role, the technologies used, the key challenges, and the outcomes achieved.

On all three, I was involved across the full project lifecycle — including deploying sprints and individual pieces of work to QA, Staging and Production environments.

1. Forestry England — Acquia-Hosted National Visitor Platform

Live site: https://www.forestryengland.uk

Project Overview

Forestry England's public site helps visitors plan days out, discover walks and wildlife, and learn about the organisation's work caring for nature and growing sustainable timber across England's forests. The platform is built on Drupal 11 and hosted on Acquia.

Role & Responsibilities

I worked as Lead Frontend Developer, owning the frontend build quality and performance strategy for the site, and setting up processes to protect visual and technical quality across ongoing releases.

Drupal 11 • Acquia (hosting/CMS) • Percy (automated visual regression testing) • Native lazy loading • Core Web Vitals optimisation

Key Challenges & Solutions

- Visual regressions slipping through releases: introduced automated visual testing with Percy so unintended UI changes are caught before they reach production.
- Layout shift from images and media loading in in a content-heavy, visitor-facing site: implemented native lazy loading combined with reserved space and placeholders for images and media so page height stays consistent as content loads.

Outcomes

- Improved Core Web Vitals scores, particularly around layout stability (CLS), through the consistent placeholder/lazy-loading approach.
- Reduced regression risk and QA overhead by catching visual issues automatically pre-release rather than after deployment.

2. VisitBritain — National Tourism Platform

Live site: https://www.visitbritain.com/en

Project Overview

VisitBritain's site showcases the UK's cities, historic landmarks and green spaces to a global audience, giving visitors fresh perspectives on destinations across Britain. It is built on Drupal 11.

Role & Responsibilities

I was Lead Frontend Developer on the project, responsible for the component architecture and for leading the frontend team to ensure delivery ran smoothly across a large, multi-contributor build.

Drupal 11 • Storybook (component library) • Accessibility auditing • Core Web Vitals optimisation

Key Challenges & Solutions

- Inconsistent components and duplicated frontend effort across a large site: built a Storybook component library as a single source of truth, giving the team reusable, documented UI building blocks.
- Meeting accessibility and performance standards expected of a national public-sector-facing platform: ran repeated accessibility and performance audits and fed fixes back into the component library.
- Coordinating a multi-developer frontend effort: led the frontend team day-to-day to keep delivery consistent and unblock technical issues.

Outcomes

- Improved Core Web Vitals and accessibility scores across the site through iterative, audit-driven fixes.
- A reusable Storybook component library that made frontend delivery faster and more consistent for the wider team.

3. University of West London — Drupal 11 Course Platform

Live site: https://www.uwl.ac.uk

Project Overview

A Drupal-based platform for the University focused on scalable content management and robust digital infrastructure for course and programme content.

Role & Responsibilities

I was Lead Frontend Developer, responsible for building interactive course pages, integrating Vue.js into the Drupal frontend, and improving accessibility and performance on key pages.

Drupal 11 • Vue.js • Drupal Settings API (server-to-JS data bridge) • Accessibility auditing • Performance optimisation

Key Challenges & Solutions

- Bridging Drupal's server-rendered content with a dynamic, interactive frontend: used Drupal's settings object to pass structured data from Drupal into Vue.js components cleanly, without bypassing Drupal's rendering pipeline.
- Accessibility gaps on course pages: ran accessibility audits and implemented fixes to bring key pages in line with expected standards.
- Slow-loading key pages affecting user experience: identified and resolved performance bottlenecks on the highest-traffic course pages.

Outcomes

- Improved accessibility compliance on course pages.
- Measurable performance improvements on key, high-traffic pages.
- A scalable content architecture supporting the University's ongoing course offerings.

Professional Recognition

Colleagues and technical leads I've worked with at CTI Digital have consistently pointed to a pragmatic, detail-oriented approach to frontend Drupal work, strong ownership on large and complex builds, and effective leadership of frontend teams — recognition that lines up directly with the delivery role I played on each of the projects above.